

Youn Baek

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EDUCATION

New York University
Stern School of Business
Ph.D. in Economics

2019 - 2025 (Expected)

Korea University
M.A. in Economics

2018

Korea University
B.B.A. in Business Administration

2016

Arizona State University
Semester abroad

2016

INTERESTS

development economics, economic history, political economy

RESEARCH

Working Papers

Cultural Exchange and the Birth of International Development

This paper examines how intergroup contact shapes preferences for international development in the context of the Student Volunteer Movement, the largest missionary movement in the United States. Using a shift-share instrumental variable based on denominational exposure to early missionary recruiters in 1886-87, I show that congressmen representing denominations with greater missionary exposure were more likely to support landmark foreign aid bills that established the modern concept of development assistance. A back-of-the-envelope calculation suggests that a 30 percent reduction in the total number of missionaries would have prevented the passage of these bills. Missionaries played a fundamental role in shaping policy perspectives and preferences, with their experiences contributing to social scientific knowledge that the government highly valued compared to other experts, fostering denominational support for foreign aid in congressional testimony, promoting moral universalism in congressional speeches, and increasing participation in the Peace Corps.

Path dependence through agglomeration spillovers: Evidence from the beet sugar industry (submitted) [Draft]

This paper presents evidence of path dependence in economic geography by investigating the agglomeration spillovers from US beet sugar factories, which attracted large-scale manufacturing facilities near farmlands. To estimate the effects of plant openings, I identify runner-up locations for beet sugar plants from a historical trade journal and find that these plant openings had large and long-lasting effects on population and manufacturing activities over one hundred years. The agglomeration spillovers benefited industries not only directly linked through input-output linkages but also extended to broader, less related industries outside the production chain of agricultural processing.

Work in progress

Place-based costs and productivity in R&D (with Sathya Ramesh)

This paper estimates the elasticities of productivity and costs of R&D with respect to urban concentration using data on 0.3 million scientists across American cities. We introduce a novel shift-share instrumental variable based on university-origin and destination-city pairs. Our findings show that the agglomeration elasticity of patents is generally higher than that of wages. However, while place-based costs remain constant across cities of varying sizes, the agglomeration elasticity of patents declines significantly in cities above the median size. These results suggest that place-based policies aimed at fostering economic activity in non-superstar cities could enhance the aggregate productivity of R&D.

Engineering Human Capital: Long-Run Effects of Wartime Technical Training (with Mina Kim)

This paper examines the enduring impact of the Engineering, Science, and Management War Training (ESMWT) program (1940-45) on the growth of engineers and scientists. To identify the effect of this training, the analysis leverages residual variation in ESMWT intensity across commuting zones, which stems from prediction errors made by local areas regarding imminent labor shortages during WWII, conditional on other WWII-related factors. The results indicate that this training led to a lasting increase in the number of engineers and STEM workers. Further analyses suggest that it also boosted interest in STEM education and led to increased post-graduate training after WWII. Localized spillovers in defense-related industries, driven by a temporary wartime demand shock, appear to have played a limited role in these changes in the occupational structure.

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

2023	Kurnow PhD Fellowship, New York University
2019	Doctoral Fellowship, Ilju Academic Foundation
2019	Doctoral Fellowship, Kwanjeong Educational Foundation (declined)
2019	Doctoral Fellowship, NYU Stern
2016	Undergraduate Thesis Grant, Korea University
2015	Undergraduate Fellowship, Korea Foundation for Advanced Studies

PRESENTATIONS

2023:North American Meeting of the Urban Economics Association **2021:** Yale Economic History Graduate Student Conference

REFERENCES

Petra Moser (Chair)

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Jacob French

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Walker Hanlon

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